

Week 28 Family Cookbook Packet

Week of: Sunday, July 5, 2026 through Saturday, July 11, 2026
Packet owner: Family
Planning status: Draft

Week Goals

- Keep meals protein-forward.
- Preserve international variety across the week.
- Schedule perishable ingredients first.
- Use clear grocery specifications.
- Use arrowroot instead of cornstarch unless a recipe specifically requires cornstarch.
- Test Stage 1 recipes before promoting anything to Stage 2.

Weekly Menu

Day	Meal	Recipe file	Stage	Protein	Cuisine/flavor	Perishability reason	Notes
Sunday, July 5	Jamaican Jerk Chicken with Coconut Rice and Pineapple Mango Salsa	jamaican-jerk-chicken-coconut-rice-pineapple-mango-salsa.md	Stage 1	Chicken thighs	Jamaican-inspired jerk	Uses fresh chicken, mango, pineapple, cilantro, and peppers	Grill-friendly Sunday meal
Monday, July 6	Mongolian Beef with Jasmine Rice and Broccoli	mongolian-beef-jasmine-rice-broccoli.md	Stage 1	Beef	Chinese-American takeout-inspired	Fresh beef and broccoli are best early	Quick weeknight meal
Tuesday, July 7	French Onion Meatballs with Creamy Mashed Potatoes and Green Beans	french-onion-meatballs-mashed-potatoes-green-beans.md	Stage 1	Ground beef	French onion-style comfort food	Ground beef and green beans should not sit too long	Richer meal, review leftovers
Wednesday, July 8	Malaysian Peanut Chicken with Jasmine Rice and Stir-Fried Vegetables	malaysian-peanut-chicken-jasmine-rice-stir-fried-vegetables.md	Stage 1	Chicken thighs	Malaysian-inspired peanut	Fresh chicken and snow peas are midweek perishables	Keep sauce savory, not too sweet
Thursday, July 9	Greek Chicken Gyro Bowls	greek-chicken-gyro-bowls.md	Stage 1	Chicken thighs	Greek-inspired bowls	Romaine, cucumber, tomato, yogurt, and chicken need freshness	Keep toppings separate
Friday, July 10	Steakhouse Garlic Butter Steak Bites with Roasted Vegetables and Crispy Baby Potatoes	steakhouse-garlic-butter-steak-bites-roasted-vegetables-potatoes.md	Stage 1	Steak	American steakhouse	Steak, mushrooms, zucchini, and squash should cook before weekend	Inspired by liked steak bites
Saturday, July 11	Baked Ziti with Italian Sausage and Garlic Sourdough Bread	baked-ziti-italian-sausage-garlic-sourdough.md	Stage 1	Italian sausage	Italian-American comfort food	Sausage and dairy hold well if kept cold	Best leftovers of the week

Recipes This Week

New recipes should start as Stage 1 drafts in this weekly folder. After cooking and review, move approved recipes to the archive with family ratings, version notes, and any changes.

Recipe	File	Stage	Goal this week	Review needed
Jamaican Jerk Chicken with Coconut Rice and Pineapple Mango Salsa	jamaican-jerk-chicken-coconut-rice-pineapple-mango-salsa.md	Stage 1	Test jerk heat level and fruit salsa pairing	Yes
Mongolian Beef with Jasmine Rice and Broccoli	mongolian-beef-jasmine-rice-broccoli.md	Stage 1	Test sauce sweetness and beef texture	Yes
French Onion Meatballs with Creamy Mashed Potatoes and Green Beans	french-onion-meatballs-mashed-potatoes-green-beans.md	Stage 1	Test onion gravy richness and leftovers	Yes
Malaysian Peanut Chicken with Jasmine Rice and Stir-Fried Vegetables	malaysian-peanut-chicken-jasmine-rice-stir-fried-vegetables.md	Stage 1	Test savory peanut balance	Yes
Greek Chicken Gyro Bowls	greek-chicken-gyro-bowls.md	Stage 1	Test bowl toppings and tzatziki amount	Yes
Steakhouse Garlic Butter Steak Bites with Roasted Vegetables and Crispy Baby Potatoes	steakhouse-garlic-butter-steak-bites-roasted-vegetables-potatoes.md	Stage 1	Test steak bite doneness and potato crispness	Yes
Baked Ziti with Italian Sausage and Garlic Sourdough Bread	baked-ziti-italian-sausage-garlic-sourdough.md	Stage 1	Test sauce-to-pasta ratio and leftovers	Yes

Grocery List

Rules:

- Recipe-driven only.
- Assume nothing is on hand.
- Do not add household staples unless required by a recipe.
- Every item needs quantity, preferred version/type, acceptable alternatives, and recipe ownership.

Produce

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
5	Limes	Fresh, juicy	Bottled lime juice if needed	Jerk Chicken, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
3	Lemons	Fresh	Bottled lemon juice	French Onion Meatballs, Greek Gyro Bowls
2 bunches	Green onions	Fresh	Chives	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef
4 bulbs	Garlic	Fresh whole bulbs	Jarred minced garlic in a pinch	All recipes except rice-only components
1 large knob	Fresh ginger	Firm, smooth skin	Ground ginger	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1	Scotch bonnet or habanero pepper	Fresh	Jalapeno	Jerk Chicken
1	Jalapeno	Fresh	Skip for mild salsa	Jerk Chicken
1	Pineapple	Fresh, ripe	20 oz canned chunks, drained	Jerk Chicken
1 large	Mango	Ripe but firm	Frozen mango, thawed and drained	Jerk Chicken
3	Red bell peppers	Fresh	Orange or yellow bell peppers	Jerk Chicken, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
3	Red onions	Medium	Shallots	Jerk Chicken, Greek Gyro Bowls
2 bunches	Cilantro	Fresh	Parsley	Jerk Chicken, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 1/2 lb	Broccoli florets	Fresh crowns or bagged florets	Frozen broccoli florets	Mongolian Beef
4 large	Yellow onions	Firm	Sweet onions	French Onion Meatballs, Baked Ziti

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
2 1/2 lb	Yukon gold potatoes	Medium potatoes	Russet potatoes	French Onion Meatballs
1 lb	Green beans	Fresh trimmed	Frozen whole green beans	French Onion Meatballs
2	English cucumbers	Firm	4 Persian cucumbers	Greek Gyro Bowls
2 hearts	Romaine lettuce	Crisp hearts	Green leaf lettuce	Greek Gyro Bowls
1 pint	Grape tomatoes	Firm, ripe	Diced tomatoes	Greek Gyro Bowls
1 bunch	Fresh dill	Fresh	Dried dill	Greek Gyro Bowls
8 oz	Snow peas	Fresh	Sugar snap peas	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
2 large	Carrots	Whole carrots	Matchstick carrots	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 1/2 lb	Baby potatoes	Small, firm	Yukon gold potatoes, cubed	Steak Bites
12 oz	Mushrooms	Cremini or baby bella	White mushrooms	Steak Bites
2 medium	Zucchini	Firm	Extra summer squash	Steak Bites
2 medium	Summer squash	Firm	Extra zucchini	Steak Bites
1 bunch	Fresh parsley	Flat-leaf preferred	Curly parsley	Steak Bites, Baked Ziti

Meat and Seafood

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
6 1/2 lb	Boneless skinless chicken thighs	Family pack, trimmed	Chicken breast, watched carefully	Jerk Chicken, Malaysian Peanut Chicken, Greek Gyro Bowls
1 1/2 lb	Flank steak	Good marbling, thin-sliced at home	Sirloin or skirt steak	Mongolian Beef
1 1/2 lb	Ground beef	85/15 or 90/10	Ground turkey	French Onion Meatballs
2 lb	Sirloin steak	Cut into 1-inch bites at home	New York strip or ribeye	Steak Bites
1 1/2 lb	Italian sausage	Mild bulk sausage	Links with casings removed	Baked Ziti

Dairy and Eggs

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
1 lb	Butter	Unsalted	Salted, reduce recipe salt	French Onion Meatballs, Steak Bites, Baked Ziti
1 quart	Milk	Whole or 2 percent	Half-and-half for richer potatoes	French Onion Meatballs
8 oz	Sour cream	Full-fat	Greek yogurt	French Onion Meatballs
4 oz	Gruyere or Swiss cheese	Shredded or block	Provolone	French Onion Meatballs
32 oz	Plain Greek yogurt	Full-fat or 2 percent	Plain yogurt, strained	Greek Gyro Bowls
15 oz	Ricotta cheese	Whole milk	Part-skim	Baked Ziti
8 oz	Mozzarella cheese	Shredded low-moisture	Italian cheese blend	Baked Ziti
4 oz	Parmesan cheese	Grated or shredded	Pecorino Romano	Baked Ziti
2 large	Eggs	Large	See recipe notes if skipping	French Onion Meatballs, Baked Ziti

Pantry and Dry Goods

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
6 cups dry	Jasmine rice	Long-grain jasmine	Long-grain white rice	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef, Malaysian Peanut Chicken, Greek Gyro Bowls
2 cans, 13.5 oz each	Coconut milk	Full-fat canned	Light coconut milk	Jerk Chicken, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 container	Arrowroot powder	Arrowroot starch	Tapioca starch	Mongolian Beef, French Onion Meatballs
1 cup	Panko breadcrumbs	Plain	Regular breadcrumbs	French Onion Meatballs
32 oz	Beef broth	Low-sodium	Beef stock	French Onion Meatballs
16 oz	Creamy peanut butter	Creamy	Crunchy peanut butter	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 lb	Ziti pasta	Dry ziti	Penne or rigatoni	Baked Ziti
32 oz	Marinara sauce	Jarred, good-quality	Homemade tomato sauce	Baked Ziti
14.5 oz	Crushed tomatoes	Canned	Diced tomatoes, crushed by hand	Baked Ziti
1 bag	Brown sugar	Light brown sugar	Dark brown sugar	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 bottle	Low-sodium soy sauce	Low-sodium	Tamari	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef, Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 bottle	Apple cider vinegar	Apple cider vinegar	White vinegar	Jerk Chicken
1 bottle	Red wine vinegar	Red wine vinegar	White vinegar	Greek Gyro Bowls
1 bottle	Worcestershire sauce	Classic	Soy sauce	French Onion Meatballs, Steak Bites
1 bottle	Fish sauce	Good-quality	Extra soy sauce	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 bottle	Toasted sesame oil	Toasted	Regular sesame oil	Mongolian Beef
1 bottle	Olive oil	Extra-virgin or regular	Avocado oil	French Onion Meatballs, Greek Gyro Bowls, Steak Bites, Baked Ziti
1 bottle	Neutral oil	Avocado or canola oil	Vegetable oil	Jerk Chicken, Mongolian Beef, Malaysian Peanut Chicken, Steak Bites
1 bag	Granulated sugar	White sugar	Honey	Greek Gyro Bowls

Sauces, Condiments, and Spices

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
1 container	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt, use less	All recipes
1 container	Black pepper	Whole peppercorns or ground	Ground black pepper	Most recipes
1 jar	Ground allspice	Ground	None	Jerk Chicken
1 jar	Dried thyme	Dried	Fresh thyme	Jerk Chicken, French Onion Meatballs, Steak Bites
1 jar	Smoked paprika	Smoked	Sweet paprika	Jerk Chicken, Greek Gyro Bowls
1 jar	Cayenne pepper	Ground	Red pepper flakes	Jerk Chicken
1 jar	Ground cinnamon	Ground	None	Jerk Chicken
1 jar	Ground nutmeg	Ground	None	Jerk Chicken

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
1 jar	Red pepper flakes	Mild	Skip for less heat	Mongolian Beef
1 jar	Garlic powder	Ground	Fresh garlic	French Onion Meatballs
1 jar	Dried oregano	Greek oregano preferred	Italian oregano	Greek Gyro Bowls
1 jar	Ground cumin	Ground	None	Malaysian Peanut Chicken, Greek Gyro Bowls
1 jar	Curry powder	Mild yellow curry powder	Malaysian curry powder	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 jar	Ground turmeric	Ground	Skip if unavailable	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 jar	Ground coriander	Ground	None	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 jar	Chili-garlic sauce	Sambal oelek or chili-garlic sauce	Sriracha	Malaysian Peanut Chicken
1 jar	Steak seasoning	Low-salt preferred	Montreal-style seasoning	Steak Bites
1 jar	Italian seasoning	Dried blend	Oregano plus basil	Baked Ziti

Frozen

No frozen items are required by this week's recipes.

Bakery

Quantity	Item	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Recipe
1 loaf	Sourdough bread	Crusty loaf	Italian bread	Baked Ziti

Prep Guide

Every prep task should include ingredients, instructions, storage method, use-by date, and meal ownership.

Sunday Dinner Support

- ☐ Make jerk marinade.
- Ingredients: Jerk Chicken marinade ingredients.
- Instructions: Blend or finely mash marinade, coat chicken, and refrigerate.
- Storage method: Covered container or zip-top bag in refrigerator.
- Use-by date: Cook Sunday, July 5.
- Meal ownership: Jamaican Jerk Chicken.
- ☐ Make pineapple mango salsa.
- Ingredients: Pineapple, mango, bell pepper, red onion, cilantro, jalapeno, lime juice, salt.
- Instructions: Dice and mix. If making more than 2 hours ahead, hold salt until serving.
- Storage method: Covered container in refrigerator.
- Use-by date: Sunday, July 5.
- Meal ownership: Jamaican Jerk Chicken.

Future Meal Prep

- ☐ Slice Mongolian beef and broccoli.
- Ingredients: Flank steak, broccoli.

- Instructions: Slice beef against the grain and cut broccoli into florets.
- Storage method: Separate covered containers in refrigerator.
- Use-by date: Monday, July 6.
- Meal ownership: Mongolian Beef.
- ☐ Shape French onion meatballs.
- Ingredients: Ground beef, egg, panko, milk, Worcestershire, garlic powder, salt, pepper.
- Instructions: Mix gently and shape into 16 to 20 meatballs.
- Storage method: Covered tray or container in refrigerator.
- Use-by date: Tuesday, July 7.
- Meal ownership: French Onion Meatballs.
- ☐ Mix Malaysian peanut sauce and cut vegetables.
- Ingredients: Peanut sauce ingredients, bell peppers, snow peas, carrots.
- Instructions: Whisk sauce smooth and slice vegetables.
- Storage method: Sauce in jar, vegetables in covered container.
- Use-by date: Wednesday, July 8.
- Meal ownership: Malaysian Peanut Chicken.

Protein Thaw Schedule

Protein	Recipe	Move from freezer to fridge	Cook date	Backup plan
Chicken thighs, 2 1/2 lb	Jamaican Jerk Chicken	Saturday, July 4	Sunday, July 5	Buy fresh Sunday morning if still frozen
Flank steak, 1 1/2 lb	Mongolian Beef	Saturday, July 4	Monday, July 6	Use sirloin strips
Ground beef, 1 1/2 lb	French Onion Meatballs	Sunday, July 5	Tuesday, July 7	Buy fresh ground beef
Chicken thighs, 2 lb	Malaysian Peanut Chicken	Monday, July 6	Wednesday, July 8	Use chicken breast
Chicken thighs, 2 lb	Greek Chicken Gyro Bowls	Tuesday, July 7	Thursday, July 9	Use chicken breast
Sirloin steak, 2 lb	Steak Bites	Wednesday, July 8	Friday, July 10	Use pre-cut steak tips
Italian sausage, 1 1/2 lb	Baked Ziti	Thursday, July 9	Saturday, July 11	Buy fresh sausage

Wednesday Refresh

- ☐ Check Thursday and Friday produce.
- Ingredients: Romaine, cucumbers, tomatoes, mushrooms, zucchini, summer squash, herbs.
- Instructions: Discard spoiled pieces, wash only what will be used soon, and move Thursday toppings to the front of the fridge.
- Storage method: Produce drawers or paper-towel-lined containers.
- Use-by date: Thursday, July 9 and Friday, July 10.
- Meal ownership: Greek Gyro Bowls, Steak Bites.
- ☐ Make Greek pickled onions and tzatziki.
- Ingredients: Red onion, vinegar, sugar, salt, Greek yogurt, cucumber, lemon, garlic, dill, olive oil.
- Instructions: Make pickled onions and tzatziki Wednesday night so Thursday bowls are faster.
- Storage method: Covered containers in refrigerator.

- Use-by date: Thursday, July 9.
- Meal ownership: Greek Chicken Gyro Bowls.

Do Not Prep Ahead

Item	Recipe	Reason not to prep early	Prep timing
Coconut rice	Jamaican Jerk Chicken	Best texture fresh	Cook Sunday before serving
Broccoli stir-fry	Mongolian Beef	Can get sulfurous and soft	Cook Monday
Mashed potatoes	French Onion Meatballs	Best texture fresh	Cook Tuesday
Romaine and tomato bowl toppings	Greek Gyro Bowls	Wilt and leak moisture	Chop Thursday
Baby potatoes	Steak Bites	Need to be dry for crisping	Boil and roast Friday
Garlic sourdough	Baked Ziti	Gets stale if toasted early	Bake Saturday

Reviews Needed After Cooking

Use `templates/recipe-review.md` for each Stage 1 recipe tested this week.

Recipe	Date cooked	Flavor	Ease	Leftovers	Cost	Time	Would make again	Decision
Jamaican Jerk Chicken							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
Mongolian Beef							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
French Onion Meatballs							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
Malaysian Peanut Chicken							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
Greek Chicken Gyro Bowls							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
Steakhouse Garlic Butter Steak Bites							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire
Baked Ziti with Italian Sausage							Yes / No / With changes	Keep Draft / Promote / Retire

Stage 2 Promotion Candidates

Only list recipes here after the family has cooked them and decided they are keepers.

Recipe	Review file	Promotion notes	Target archive folder

Leftover Plan

- Planned leftovers: Baked ziti should produce the strongest planned leftovers. French onion meatballs may also work for lunches if the gravy holds.
- Lunch conversions: Mongolian beef, Malaysian peanut chicken, and Greek chicken can become rice bowls.
- Freeze portions: Baked ziti can be frozen after baking if cooled completely and wrapped well.

- Do not save: Pineapple mango salsa may get watery after 24 hours. Romaine bowl toppings should be kept separate and used quickly.

Lessons Learned This Week

Add useful takeaways to `planning/lessons-learned.md` after the week is complete.

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Open Questions For Next Week

- Did the week feel too rice-heavy even with Saturday pasta?
- Which chicken profile was strongest: jerk, Malaysian peanut, or Greek?
- Was Friday steak worth the higher cost compared with another ground-beef meal?